THE ITERATION $x \mapsto a \bmod x$ HAS LENGTH $O_\varepsilon(a^{3/10+\varepsilon})$

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ABSTRACT. For integers $a > b > 0$ let $b_1 = b$, $b_{i+1} = a \bmod b_i$, and let $P(a,b)$ be the number of positive terms of this sequence. Shallit asked whether $P(a,b) = O((\log a)^2)$. The bound $P(a,b) \ll_\varepsilon a^{1/3+\varepsilon}$ of Erdős and Shallit was improved by Chase and Pandey to $a^{1/3-2/177+\varepsilon}$. We prove $P(a,b) \ll_\varepsilon a^{3/10+\varepsilon}$ by an elementary argument. The new ingredient is an exact identity for three consecutive steps of the iteration. It shows that a certain integer combination $D = dv - eu$ of the drops and quotient increments is always positive. It is also small whenever the three drops are small, and D together with the two increments confines the block to a curve with few integer points. A second identity, for six consecutive steps, produces a further positive integer L built from three overlapping curvatures. It gives the local bound $T \ll a^{1/2}A^{-1/3}$ for the number T of remainders in $[A, 2A)$, with no divisor-function loss. Combined with results of Nair–Tenenbaum and de la Bretèche–Tenenbaum on the Erdős–Hooley Δ-function, it gives $P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10}\sqrt{\log\log 3a}$. Everything is formalised in Lean 4 with Mathlib, without `sorry`. The last bound is formalised conditionally on the two cited theorems, which are stated in Lean as explicit hypotheses.

1. INTRODUCTION

Let $a > b > 0$ be integers. Put $b_1 = b$ and $b_{i+1} = a \bmod b_i$ while $b_i > 0$. The sequence is strictly decreasing until it reaches 0; if $b_{n+1} = 0$ we write $P(a,b) = n$. For example $P(35,22) = 7$, from $22, 13, 9, 8, 3, 2, 1, 0$. The number $P(a,b)$ is the length of the Pierce expansion of b/a [9, 10], since

$$\frac{b}{a} = \frac{1}{q_1} - \frac{1}{q_1 q_2} + \frac{1}{q_1 q_2 q_3} - \cdots, \qquad q_i = \lfloor a/b_i \rfloor.$$

Shallit [8] asked whether

$$P(a,b) = O\big((\log a)^2\big). \tag{1}$$

Shallit [10] proved $P(a,b) \ll a^{1/2}$ by "Archimedean" arguments. Erdős and Shallit [3] combined these with a divisor argument to get $P(a,b) \ll_\varepsilon a^{1/3+\varepsilon}$, and showed that $\max_b P(a,b)/\log a$ does not tend to 0. Chase and Pandey [2] went past the exponent $1/3$, proving $P(a,b) \ll_\varepsilon a^{1/3-2/177+\varepsilon}$ with exponential sum estimates (Bourgain's exponent pair), and showed that $\max_b P(a,b) \gg \log a/\log\log a$ for all large a. Shallit's talk pages [12] report a bound $n^{3/10}$, described as "LLM, unpublished so far". We have not seen that argument. The result below has the same exponent up to ε, and we make no claim about how the two arguments are related.

Theorem 1.1. *For every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a constant C_ε such that*

$$P(a,b) \le C_\varepsilon\, a^{3/10+\varepsilon} \qquad \textit{for all integers } 0 < b < a.$$

The proof is elementary. It uses only the division equations $a = q_i b_i + b_{i+1}$ and the divisor bound $\tau(n) \ll_\delta n^\delta$. As usual, the remainders are split into dyadic windows $[A, 2A)$, and we

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bound the number T of remainders in one window. There are two bounds:

$$T(T-1) \le 4A\,\Delta, \tag{2}$$

$$T^6 A^2 \le 995328\, a^3 \Delta \qquad (T \ge 12), \tag{3}$$

where Δ is the largest value of the divisor function on $[1, 32a^7]$. Bound (2) is the Erdős–Shallit argument. Bound (3) is new. Multiplying (3) by the square of (2) eliminates A and gives $T^{10} \ll a^3\Delta^3$, which is the exponent $3/10$.

The new bound comes from three consecutive steps $x = b_i$, $y = b_{i+1}$, $z = b_{i+2}$, $w = b_{i+3}$. Let d, e, f be the drops, let u, v be the increments of the quotients, and put $D = dv - eu$. Then

$$D\,z = df + ude + (u-1)e^2. \tag{4}$$

So D is a *positive* integer, even though dv and eu largely cancel, and it is small when the drops are small. Also $(q, x) = (\lfloor a/b_i \rfloor, b_i)$ lies on the curve $xM(q) = aN(q) + D$, where M and N are explicit polynomials depending on (u, v) (Lemma 3.3). A resultant-type identity shows that each such curve has $a^{o(1)}$ admissible points (Lemma 4.1). The number of triples (u, v, D) is $\ll (B/T)^2 \cdot a/T^3$, where $B = a/A$, which gives (3).

A second positive integer. Six consecutive terms carry three overlapping curvatures D, E, F and four quotient increments u, v, w, z. In Section 7 we show that the integer

$$L = \frac{S(v,w,z)\,D - S(u,v,w)\,E}{v}, \qquad S(u,v,w) = u^2v + (u-1)v^2 + uw,$$

satisfies the exact identity $qwL = J(u,v,w,z)\,E + S(u,v,w)\,F$, where J is a polynomial with positive values (Lemma 7.1). Hence $L \ge 1$, and $q \asymp a/A$ is bounded by a polynomial in the small parameters u, v, w, z, E, F. A single window of six terms with small total drop then gives

$$T^6 A^2 \le 96 \cdot 10^6\, a^3 \qquad (T \ge 10), \tag{5}$$

with no divisor function at all (Proposition 7.3).

With (5) in hand, the only remaining loss is in the drop bound (2). That loss comes from the number of divisors of $a + h$ in $[A, 2A)$ as h ranges over a short interval. Section 8 shows that any bound $\ll y\,G(x)$ for such counts over intervals $(x, x+y]$ with $y \ge x^{1/4}$ gives $P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10} G(a)^{1/5}$ (Theorem 8.3). The counts are majorised by the Erdős–Hooley function. Combining the short-sum theorem of Nair and Tenenbaum [6] with the recent mean-value bound of de la Bretèche and Tenenbaum [1] gives $G(x) = (\log\log x)^{5/2}$, and hence the following.

Theorem 1.2. *Assume the theorem of Nair–Tenenbaum stated as* (9) *and the theorem of de la Bretèche–Tenenbaum stated as* (10) *below. Then*

$$P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10}\sqrt{\log\log 3a} \qquad \textit{uniformly for integers } 0 < b < a.$$

Both hypotheses are published theorems. They are hypotheses only in the sense of the formalisation: we have not formalised their proofs. Any other short-interval divisor bound can be used in their place. For example, Shiu's theorem [11] gives $\sum_{x<n\le x+y} \tau(n) \ll y \log x$ for $y \ge x^{1/4}$, and hence $P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10}(\log a)^{1/5}$; we have not formalised that either.

Formal verification. Every step of the proof of Theorem 1.1 has been formalised in Lean 4 [4] using Mathlib [5]. So have Proposition 7.3, Theorem 8.3, and the deduction of Theorem 1.2 from (9) and (10). Section 9 describes the formalisation. The constants in this paper are the constants in the Lean proof.

What is not proved. Both theorems are far from (1), and the method cannot reach it; see Section 10.

2. Preliminaries

2.1. **Notation.** Throughout, $a > b > 0$ are integers, $b_1 = b$, $b_{i+1} = a \bmod b_i$, and $P = P(a,b)$, so that $a > b_1 > b_2 > \cdots > b_P > 0 = b_{P+1}$. Write $q_i = \lfloor a/b_i \rfloor$, so

$$a = q_i b_i + b_{i+1}, \qquad 0 \le b_{i+1} < b_i \qquad (1 \le i \le P).$$

Let $\tau(n)$ be the number of positive divisors of n, and let

$$\Delta = \Delta(a) = \max_{1 \le n \le 32a^7} \tau(n).$$

Lemma 2.1 (Quotients increase)**.** *If $b_{i+1} > 0$ then $q_{i+1} \ge q_i + 1$.*

Proof. Since $b_{i+1} < b_i$ we have $(q_i+1)b_{i+1} \le q_i b_i + b_{i+1} = a$, so $q_{i+1} = \lfloor a/b_{i+1} \rfloor \ge q_i + 1$. □

Lemma 2.2 (Divisor bound)**.** *For every integer $k \ge 1$ there is C_k with $\tau(n)^k \le C_k\, n$ for all $n \ge 1$.*

Proof. This is standard: $\tau(n)^k/n = \prod_{p^\alpha \| n} (\alpha+1)^k / p^\alpha$. Each factor with $p \ge 2^k$ is at most $(\alpha+1)^k/2^{k\alpha} \le 1$. Each of the fewer than 2^k factors with $p < 2^k$ is at most $\sup_\alpha (\alpha+1)^k/2^\alpha < \infty$. □

2.2. **Window runs.**

Definition 2.3. Let $A \ge 1$. A *window run* of length T is a sequence $x_0, x_1, \ldots, x_{T-1}$ of consecutive terms of the sequence (b_i), so $x_{j+1} = a \bmod x_j$, all lying in $[A, 2A)$.

In a window run, $x_0 > x_1 > \cdots > x_{T-1}$ and $x_j \le a$.

3. The curvature of three consecutive steps

Fix four consecutive terms

$$x = b_i, \quad y = b_{i+1} = a \bmod x, \quad z = b_{i+2} = a \bmod y, \quad w = b_{i+3} = a \bmod z,$$

with $x, y, z > 0$ (and $w \ge 0$). Write

$$q = \left\lfloor \frac{a}{x} \right\rfloor, \quad u = \left\lfloor \frac{a}{y} \right\rfloor - q, \quad v = \left\lfloor \frac{a}{z} \right\rfloor - \left\lfloor \frac{a}{y} \right\rfloor, \qquad d = x - y, \quad e = y - z, \quad f = z - w.$$

By Lemma 2.1, $u, v \ge 1$, and clearly $d, e, f \ge 1$. The division equations read

$$xq + y = a, \qquad y(q+u) + z = a, \qquad z(q+u+v) + w = a. \tag{6}$$

Definition 3.1. The *curvature* of the block is $D = dv - eu$.

Lemma 3.2 (Curvature identity)**.**

$$D\,z = df + ude + (u-1)e^2.$$

In particular $D \ge 1$.

Proof. Subtracting the first two equations of (6) gives $uy = qd + e$, hence $uz = uy - ue = qd + (1-u)e$. Subtracting the last two gives $vz = (q+u)e + f$. Therefore

$$(dv - eu)z = d\big((q+u)e + f\big) - e\big(qd + (1-u)e\big) = df + ude + (u-1)e^2.$$

The right-hand side is at least $df \ge 1$, and $z > 0$, so $D > 0$. □

Equivalently, the identity is the linear combination

$$Dz - \big(df + ude + (u-1)e^2\big) = d\,E_3 + (a - qx - x - y + z)\,E_2 + (-a + (q+u)y + y)\,E_1$$

of the three division equations E_1, E_2, E_3 of (6) (each written as left $-$ right $= 0$). This is how it is checked in Lean.

Lemma 3.3 (The fiber equation)**.** *Put $M(q) = uq^2 + (u^2+u+v)q + v$ and $N(q) = uq + u^2 + v$. Then*

$$x\,M(q) = a\,N(q) + D.$$

Proof. From (6), $d = (q+1)x - a$ and $e = y - z = (q+u+1)y - a = a(q+u) - q(q+u+1)x$. Substituting these into $D = dv - eu$ gives $D = x\big(uq(q+u+1) + v(q+1)\big) - a\big(u(q+u) + v\big)$, which is the claim. □

Lemma 3.4 (Size of the parameters)**.** *If $x \le a$ then*

$$u\,yx \le a(d+e), \qquad v\,zy \le a(e+f), \qquad D\,z \le (u+1)(d+e+f)^2.$$

Proof. From $uy = qd + e$ we get $uyx = (qx)d + ex \le ad + ae$, since $qx \le a$ and $x \le a$. Similarly $vz = (q+u)e + f$ with $(q+u)y \le a$ and $y \le a$ gives the second bound. For the third, by Lemma 3.2, $Dz = df + ude + (u-1)e^2 \le df + u\,e(d+e) \le (1+u)(d+e+f)^2$. □

4. Few blocks share a triple (u, v, D)

Lemma 4.1 (Fiber count)**.** *Let $a \ge 1$, $1 \le u, v \le a$ and $1 \le D \le 2a$. Let $M(q) = uq^2 + pq + v$ with $p = u^2 + u + v$, and let $L(q) = cq + \ell$ with $c = au$ and $\ell = a(u^2+v) + D$. Then the set*

$$Q = \{q \ge 0 :\ xM(q) = L(q) \text{ for some integer } x \ge 1\}$$

has at most $\Delta = \max_{n \le 32a^7} \tau(n)$ elements.

Proof. Put $U(q) = ucq + cp - u\ell$ and $R = u\ell^2 - cp\ell + c^2 v$. Expanding shows

$$c^2 M(q) - U(q)L(q) = R \tag{7}$$

identically in q. If $q \in Q$ with witness x, substituting $L(q) = xM(q)$ into (7) gives

$$R = M(q)\big(c^2 - U(q)x\big). \tag{8}$$

We bound the sizes first. From $u, v \le a$ and $D \le 2a$ we get $\ell \le 4a^3$, $p \le 3a^2$ and $c \le a^2$, so

$$|R| \le u\ell^2 + cp\ell + c^2 v \le 16a^7 + 12a^7 + a^5 \le 32a^7, \qquad c^2 \le a^4 \le 32a^7.$$

Case $R \ne 0$. By (8), $M(q)$ is a positive divisor of $|R|$. Since $u, p \ge 1$, the map $q \mapsto M(q)$ is strictly increasing on $q \ge 0$, hence injective. Therefore $|Q| \le \tau(|R|) \le \Delta$.

Case $R = 0$. Since $M(q) > 0$, (8) gives $U(q)x = c^2$. Here $c^2 > 0$ and $x \ge 1$, so $U(q)$ is a positive divisor of c^2. Since U is linear with positive leading coefficient uc, it is injective. Therefore $|Q| \le \tau(c^2) \le \Delta$. □

The case $R = 0$ cannot be dropped: it is the case in which M and L might share a factor.

5. Counting visits to a window

In this section $x_0, \dots, x_{T-1}$ is a window run in $[A, 2A)$, and $\Delta = \max_{n \le 32a^7} \tau(n)$.

Proposition 5.1 (Drop bound; after Erdős–Shallit)**.** *If $T \ge 2$ then $T(T-1) \le 4A\Delta$.*

Proof. Let $h_j = x_j - x_{j+1} \ge 1$ for $0 \le j \le T-2$. By telescoping, $\sum_j h_j = x_0 - x_{T-1} \le (2A-1) - A = A - 1$. Call j *good* if $h_j(T-1) \le 2A$ and *bad* otherwise. Each bad j has $h_j(T-1) \ge 2A+1$, so

$$|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,|\,(2A+1) \le (T-1)\textstyle\sum_j h_j \le (T-1)(A-1).$$

If $2|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,| \ge T-1$ this would give $(T-1)(2A+1) \le 2(T-1)(A-1)$, which is false. Hence $2|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,| < T-1$, and since $|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| + |\,\mathrm{Bad}\,| = T-1$ we get $2|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| \ge T$.

For good j we have $1 \le h_j \le H := \lfloor 2A/(T-1) \rfloor$. Also $a + h_j = q_j x_j + x_{j+1} + x_j - x_{j+1} = (q_j+1)x_j$, so $x_j \mid a + h_j$. Moreover $a + h_j \le 2a \le 32a^7$. Since $j \mapsto x_j$ is injective, at most $\tau(a+h) \le \Delta$ good indices have $h_j = h$. Hence $|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| \le H\Delta$, and

$$T(T-1) \le 2|\,\mathrm{Good}\,|(T-1) \le 2\Delta\, H(T-1) \le 4A\Delta. \qquad \square$$

Proposition 5.2 (Curvature bound)**.** *If $T \ge 12$ then $T^6A^2 \le 995328\, a^3\Delta$.*

Proof. For $0 \le j \le T-4$ let $s_j = x_j - x_{j+3}$ be the total drop of the block $x_j, x_{j+1}, x_{j+2}, x_{j+3}$. By telescoping,

$$\sum_{j=0}^{T-4} s_j = (x_0 + x_1 + x_2) - (x_{T-3} + x_{T-2} + x_{T-1}) \le 3(2A-1) - 3A = 3A - 3.$$

Call j *good* if $s_j T \le 12A$ and *bad* otherwise. Then $|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,|(12A+1) \le T(3A-3)$. If $4|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,| \ge T$ this would give $T(12A+1) \le 4T(3A-3)$, which is false. So $4|\,\mathrm{Bad}\,| \le T-1$. Since $|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| = T - 3 - |\,\mathrm{Bad}\,|$ and $T \ge 12$,

$$2|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| \ge 2T - 6 - \tfrac{T-1}{2} \ge T.$$

Fix a good j. Apply Section 3 to $x = x_j$, so that $y, z, w = x_{j+1}, x_{j+2}, x_{j+3}$, all in $[A, 2A)$. Write $s = s_j = d + e + f$. Lemma 3.4 gives $uA^2 \le uyx \le a(d+e) \le as$. Multiplying by T and using $sT \le 12A$ gives $uA^2T \le 12aA$, that is,

$$u\,AT \le 12a, \qquad \text{and likewise} \qquad v\,AT \le 12a.$$

Also $DA \le Dz \le (u+1)s^2 \le 2us^2$. Multiplying by T^2 gives $DAT^2 \le 2u(sT)^2 \le 288uA^2$, so $DT^2 \le 288uA$, and then

$$D\,T^3 \le 288\,u\,AT \le 3456\,a.$$

Thus the triple (u, v, D) of a good block lies in $[1, U]^2 \times [1, D^*]$, where

$$U = \lfloor 12a/(AT) \rfloor \le a, \qquad D^* = \lfloor 3456a/T^3 \rfloor \le 2a.$$

The inequalities $U \le a$ and $D^* \le 2a$ hold because $AT \ge 12$ and $T^3 \ge 1728$.

Now fix such a triple and consider the good blocks that have it. By Lemma 3.3, each one gives a point $q = q_j = \lfloor a/x_j \rfloor$ of the set Q of Lemma 4.1. The map $j \mapsto q_j$ is injective on these blocks: q_j determines $x_j = L(q_j)/M(q_j)$, and x_j determines j. By Lemma 4.1, at most Δ good blocks share a triple. So $|\,\mathrm{Good}\,| \le U^2 D^* \Delta$, and

$$T^6A^2 = T\,(AT)^2\,T^3 \le 2\Delta\,(U\,AT)^2\,(D^*T^3) \le 2\Delta(12a)^2(3456a) = 995328\,a^3\Delta. \qquad \square$$

Corollary 5.3 (Window bound)**.** *If $T \ge 12$ then $T^{10} \le 63700992\, a^3\Delta^3$.*

Proof. Using $T \le 2(T-1)$ and the two propositions,

$$T^{10}A^2 \le 4\,(T^6A^2)\,\big(T(T-1)\big)^2 \le 4\cdot 995328\,a^3\Delta\cdot(4A\Delta)^2 = 63700992\,a^3\Delta^3A^2.$$

Divide by A^2. □

Remark 5.4. In terms of $B = a/A$, Propositions 5.1 and 5.2 say $T \ll a^{1/2+o(1)}B^{-1/2}$ and $T \ll a^{1/6+o(1)}B^{1/3}$. The first is better when $B > a^{2/5}$, and both equal $a^{3/10+o(1)}$ at $B = a^{2/5}$. Corollary 5.3 takes the product of the two bounds, so no case split is needed.

6. Proof of Theorem 1.1

Let $0 < b < a$. For $0 \le k \le \log_2 a$ let T_k be the number of indices $i \le P$ with $2^k \le b_i < 2^{k+1}$. Every b_i with $i \le P$ lies in $[1, a)$, so $P = \sum_{0\le k\le \log_2 a} T_k$. Since (b_i) is decreasing, the indices counted by T_k are consecutive. So when $T_k > 0$ they form a window run in $[A, 2A)$ with $A = 2^k$.

Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Choose an integer $m > 7/(5\varepsilon)$, and let C_{3m} be the constant of Lemma 2.2 with $k = 3m$. The maximum Δ is attained at some $n_0 \le 32a^7$, so $\Delta^{3m} \le C_{3m}\cdot 32a^7$. If $T_k \ge 12$, Corollary 5.3 gives

$$T_k^{10m} \le 63700992^m\,a^{3m}\,\Delta^{3m} \le K\,a^{3m+7}, \qquad K = 63700992^m\cdot C_{3m}\cdot 32,$$

and hence

$$T_k \le K^{1/(10m)}\,a^{3/10+7/(10m)} \le K^{1/(10m)}\,a^{3/10+\varepsilon/2}.$$

If $T_k \le 11$ this bound holds with 11 in place of $K^{1/(10m)}$. Finally $\lfloor \log_2 a\rfloor + 1 \le C'_\varepsilon a^{\varepsilon/2}$. Summing over k,

$$P(a,b) \le (\lfloor \log_2 a\rfloor + 1)\big(11 + K^{1/(10m)}\big)a^{3/10+\varepsilon/2} \le C_\varepsilon\,a^{3/10+\varepsilon}. \qquad \square$$

7. Six consecutive steps

Fix six consecutive terms $x_0 > x_1 > \cdots > x_5 \ge 0$ of the sequence (b_i) with $x_4 > 0$, and write their quotients as

$$\lfloor a/x_0\rfloor = q, \quad \lfloor a/x_1\rfloor = q+u, \quad \lfloor a/x_2\rfloor = q+u+v,$$
$$\lfloor a/x_3\rfloor = q+u+v+w, \quad \lfloor a/x_4\rfloor = q+u+v+w+z.$$

(In this section w is a quotient increment, not a term of the sequence.) By Lemma 2.1, $u, v, w, z \ge 1$. Let $f_k = x_k - x_{k+1} \ge 1$ be the drops, and let

$$D = f_0v - f_1u, \qquad E = f_1w - f_2v, \qquad F = f_2z - f_3w$$

be the curvatures of the blocks starting at x_0, x_1 and x_2. Write E_k for the division equation $x_kq_k + x_{k+1} - a = 0$, where $q_k = \lfloor a/x_k\rfloor$. Put

$$S(u,v,w) = u^2v + (u-1)v^2 + uw,$$
$$J(u,v,w,z) = \big(u^2+(u-1)v\big)z + w\big(u^3 + uv(2u-1) + (u-1)v^2\big) + w^2\big((u-1)(u+v)+1\big),$$
$$L = (vw + w^2 + z)\,D - \big(u^2+(u-1)v\big)E - w\,(wf_0 - uf_2).$$

Lemma 7.1 (The six-step identity)**.** (1) $S(v,w,z)\,D - S(u,v,w)\,E = v\,L$.
(2) $q\,w\,L = J(u,v,w,z)\,E + S(u,v,w)\,F$.

Proof. Part (1) is a polynomial identity: since $S(v,w,z) \equiv -w^2$ and $S(u,v,w) \equiv uw \pmod v$, and $wD + uE = v(wf_0 - uf_2)$, the difference is divisible by v, and expanding gives L. Part (2) holds modulo the division equations. Explicitly, $qwL - JE - S(u,v,w)F$ equals

$$w(v^2w + vw^2 + vz - w^2)\,E_0 - w(u^2w + 2uvw + uw^2 + uz + v^2w + vw^2 - vw + vz - w^2)\,E_1$$
$$+ w(u^2v + u^2w + uv^2 + 2uvw + uw^2 + uw + uz - v^2 - vw)\,E_2 - w(u^2v + uv^2 + uw - v^2)\,E_3.$$

This is an identity of polynomials in a, q, the x_k and the increments, checked by expansion. □

Corollary 7.2. *Suppose $q \geq 1$ and $u, v, w, z \leq m$. Then $E, F \geq 1$, $L \geq 1$, and*

$$q \leq 9m^3E + 3m^3F.$$

Proof. Lemma 3.2, applied to the blocks starting at x_1 and x_2, gives $E, F \geq 1$. Clearly $J > 0$ and $S \geq 0$, so by Lemma 7.1(2) $qwL > 0$. Since L is an integer, $L \geq 1$ and $qw \leq JE + SF$. Bounding each monomial gives $J \leq 9m^3w$ and $S(u,v,w) \leq 3m^3w$. Dividing by w gives the claim. □

So the quotient q, which is about a/A, is controlled by the small parameters of a single block of six terms. No counting over many blocks is needed.

Proposition 7.3 (Six-step window bound)**.** *For a window run of length $T \geq 10$,*

$$T^6A^2 \leq 96 \cdot 10^6\, a^3.$$

Proof. For $0 \leq j \leq T-6$ let $s_j = x_j - x_{j+5}$. By telescoping, $\sum_{j \leq T-6} s_j \leq 5(2A-1) - 5A = 5A-5$. So some j has $s_j(T-5) \leq 5A-5$, and since $T \leq 2(T-5)$, we get $s := s_j$ with $sT \leq 10A$. Apply Corollary 7.2 to $x_j, \ldots, x_{j+5}$, all of which lie in $[A, 2A)$, with $m = \max(u,v,w,z)$.

By Lemma 3.4 at $x_j, \ldots, x_{j+3}$, each increment satisfies (increment) $\cdot\, A^2 \leq as$. Multiplying by T gives $mAT \leq 10a$. By Lemma 3.4 again, $EA \leq Ex_{j+3} \leq (v+1)s^2 \leq 2ms^2$, and likewise $FA \leq 2ms^2$. Hence $qA \leq 24m^4s^2$. Also $a = qx_j + x_{j+1} < (q+1)x_j < 2A(q+1) \leq 4Aq$. Therefore

$$qA \cdot A^4T^6 \leq 24\,(mAT)^4(sT)^2 \leq 24 \cdot 10^6\, a^4A^2,$$

so $qA^3T^6 \leq 24 \cdot 10^6 a^4$, and $aA^2T^6 \leq 4qA^3T^6 \leq 96 \cdot 10^6\, a^4$. □

Remark 7.4. In terms of $B = a/A$, Proposition 7.3 reads $T \ll a^{1/6}B^{1/3}$. This is Proposition 5.2 without the factor $\Delta^{1/6}$. Combined with Proposition 5.1 as in Corollary 5.3, it gives $T^{10} \ll a^3\Delta^2$ and another proof of Theorem 1.1. The Lean proof of Theorem 1.1 uses Corollary 5.3.

8. Divisors over short intervals

For $A \geq 1$ let $\tau_A(n) = \#\{d \mid n :\ A \leq d < 2A\}$.

Proposition 8.1 (Drop count)**.** *For a window run of length $T \geq 2$ and any $Y \geq \lfloor 2A/(T-1) \rfloor$,*

$$T \leq 2 \sum_{a < n \leq a+Y} \tau_A(n).$$

Proof. This is the proof of Proposition 5.1, stopped before the divisor bound. The good indices j have $1 \leq h_j \leq \lfloor 2A/(T-1) \rfloor$, and $j \mapsto x_j$ maps those with $h_j = h$ injectively into the divisors of $a + h$ in $[A, 2A)$. □

Definition 8.2. Let $G\colon \mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{R}$. We say that SD($G$) holds if there are C, x_0 such that for all integers $x \geq x_0$, $x^{1/4} \leq y \leq x$ and $A \geq 1$,

$$\sum_{x < n \leq x+y} \tau_A(n) \leq C\, y\, G(x).$$

Theorem 8.3. *Suppose* $\mathrm{SD}(G)$ *holds,* $G \geq 1$*, and* $G(x) \ll x^{1/40}$*. Then* $P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10}\, G(a)^{1/5}$ *uniformly for* $0 < b < a$*.*

Proof. Small a are handled by $P(a,b) \leq b < a$. Fix a dyadic window $[A, 2A)$, $A = 2^k$, with $T \geq 20$ visits. Proposition 7.3 gives $T \leq \alpha A^{-1/3}$, where $\alpha = (96 \cdot 10^6)^{1/6} a^{1/2}$. Take $Y = \max(\lfloor 2A/(T-1) \rfloor, \lceil a^{1/4} \rceil) \leq a$ in Proposition 8.1. With $H = \lfloor 2A/(T-1) \rfloor$, $\mathrm{SD}(G)$ gives $T \leq 2CG(a)(H + a^{1/4} + 1)$. Multiplying by $T-1$, using $H(T-1) \leq 2A$, and solving the quadratic gives $T \leq \gamma + \beta A^{1/2}$, where $\beta = 4\sqrt{CG(a)}$ and $\gamma = 4CG(a)(a^{1/4}+1)$. So every window satisfies

$$T_k \leq 19 + \gamma + \min\bigl(\alpha\, 2^{-k/3},\ \beta\, 2^{k/2}\bigr).$$

Let $M = \alpha^{3/5}\beta^{2/5}$. Since $X^3Y^2 = M^5$ for $X = \alpha 2^{-k/3}$ and $Y = \beta 2^{k/2}$, for each k either $Y \leq M$ or $X < M$. So the minimum is at most the sum of a geometric series with ratio $\sqrt{2}$ capped at M, plus one with ratio $2^{-1/3}$ capped at M. This gives

$$\sum_k \min\bigl(\alpha\, 2^{-k/3},\ \beta\, 2^{k/2}\bigr) \leq 9\, \alpha^{3/5}\beta^{2/5} \ll a^{3/10} G(a)^{1/5},$$

with no factor $\log a$. The remaining terms contribute $(\log_2 a + 1)(19 + \gamma) \ll a^{1/100} \cdot a^{1/4} G(a)$. This is $\ll a^{3/10} G(a)^{1/5}$, because $G(a)^{4/5} \ll a^{1/50}$. □

The Erdős–Hooley function. Let $\Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) = \max_{u \in \mathbb{R}} \#\{d \mid n : \ e^u < d \leq e^{u+1}\}$. Taking $e^{u+1} = 2A$, and using $e > 2$, gives $\tau_A(n) \leq \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n)$. We use two published theorems.

(NT) Nair and Tenenbaum [6] prove a general upper bound for short sums of functions F satisfying $F(mn) \leq \min(A^{\Omega(m)}, Bm^{\varepsilon})F(n)$ for $(m,n) = 1$. They note that Δ_{H} is such a function. In their introduction they record the consequence, for $Q(X) = X$ and $t = 1$, that for x large and $x^{\varepsilon} \leq y \leq x$

$$\sum_{x < n \leq x+y} \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) \ll_{\varepsilon} \frac{y}{\log x} \sum_{n \leq x} \frac{\Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n)}{n}. \tag{9}$$

We use it with $\varepsilon = 1/4$.

(BT) de la Bretèche and Tenenbaum [1, Theorem 1.1] prove that for large x

$$\sum_{n \leq x} \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) \ll x\, (\log\log x)^{5/2}. \tag{10}$$

Lemma 8.4. *Assume* (10)*, and let* $\ell(x) = \max(1, \log\log x)$*. Then* $\sum_{n \leq x} \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n)/n \ll \log x \cdot \ell(x)^{5/2}$ *for large* x*.*

Proof. Split n into dyadic blocks $2^j \leq n < 2^{j+1} \leq 2x$. The terms with n below the threshold of (10) contribute $O(1)$, since $\Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) \leq n$. Each remaining block contributes at most $2^{-j} \sum_{n \leq 2^{j+1}} \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) \ll \ell(2x)^{5/2}$, and $\ell(2x) \leq 2\ell(x)$. There are at most $\log_2 x + 1 \leq 3 \log x$ blocks. □

Proof of Theorem 1.2. By (9) and Lemma 8.4, $\sum_{x < n \leq x+y} \tau_A(n) \leq \sum_{x < n \leq x+y} \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}(n) \ll y\, \ell(x)^{5/2}$ for $x^{1/4} \leq y \leq x$. So $\mathrm{SD}(G)$ holds with $G = \ell^{5/2}$, which satisfies $G \geq 1$ and $G(x) \ll x^{1/40}$. Theorem 8.3 gives $P(a,b) \ll a^{3/10} \ell(a)^{1/2} \ll a^{3/10} \sqrt{\log\log 3a}$. □

9. The Lean formalisation

The repository accompanying this paper contains a Lean 4 project (toolchain `v4.35.0`, Mathlib `v4.35.0`) that proves Theorem 1.1. The final statement is

```
theorem P_le : ∀ ε > (0 : ℝ), ∃ C > 0, ∀ a b : ℕ, 0 < b → b < a →
    (P a b : ℝ) ≤ C * (a : ℝ) ^ ((3 : ℝ) / 10 + ε)
```

where `P a b` is defined by well-founded recursion as the number of positive terms ($P(a,0)=0$, $P(a,b)=P(a,a \bmod b)+1$ for $b>0$), and the file checks $P(35,22)=7$. Theorem 1.2 is formalised as

```
theorem P_le_loglog (hNT : NairTenenbaumDelta)
    (hBT : BretecheTenenbaumMean) :
    ∃ C > 0, ∀ a b : ℕ, 0 < b → b < a →
    (P a b : ℝ) ≤ C * (a : ℝ) ^ (3 / 10 : ℝ)
        * √(Real.log (Real.log (3 * a)))
```

Here `NairTenenbaumDelta` and `BretecheTenenbaumMean` are Lean propositions stating (9) (with $\varepsilon = 1/4$) and (10), with existential constants and thresholds. `hooleyDelta` is defined as the supremum over $u \in \mathbb{R}$, exactly as above. For `P_le`, `six_step_bound`, `P_le_of_shortDivisorBound` and `P_le_loglog`, the command `#print axioms` reports only `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`. There is no `sorry` and no `native_decide`.

Paper	Lean	File
Definition of $P(a,b)$	`P`, `orb`	`Defs.lean`
Lemma 2.1	`div_lt_div_mod`	`Block.lean`
Lemma 3.2	`curvature_identity`, `one_le_bD`	`Block.lean`
Lemma 3.3	`fiber_identity`, `block_fiber_eq`	`Block.lean`
Lemma 3.4	`bu_mul_le`, `bv_mul_le`, `bD_mul_le`	`Block.lean`
Lemma 4.1	`fiber_poly_identity`, `fiber_card_le`	`Fiber.lean`
Window runs	`Window`, `DivBound`	`Window.lean`
Proposition 5.1	`drop_bound`	`Window.lean`
Proposition 5.2	`curvature_bound`	`Window.lean`
Corollary 5.3	`window_bound`	`Window.lean`
Dyadic decomposition	`P_eq_sum_visits`, `visits_window`	`Main.lean`
Theorem 1.1	`P_le`	`Main.lean`
Lemma 2.2	`exists_divisors_power_bound`	`DivisorPowerBound.lean`
Lemma 7.1	`six_divisibility`, `six_identity`	`SixStep.lean`
Corollary 7.2	`six_core`	`SixStep.lean`
Proposition 7.3	`six_step_bound`	`SixStep.lean`
Proposition 8.1	`drop_count_bound'`	`ShortSum.lean`
Geometric sum	`sum_min_le`	`Geometric.lean`
Theorem 8.3	`P_le_of_shortDivisorBound`	`Conditional.lean`
Δ_{H}, $\tau_A \le \Delta_{\mathrm{H}}$	`hooleyDelta`, `dcount_le_hooleyDelta`	`Hooley.lean`
(9), (10)	`NairTenenbaumDelta`, `BretecheTenenbaumMean`	`Hooley.lean`
Lemma 8.4	`sum_hooleyDelta_div_le`	`Hooley.lean`
Theorem 1.2	`P_le_loglog`	`Hooley.lean`

Some details of the formalisation:

- The algebraic identities (Lemmas 3.2, 3.3 and (7)) are proved over $\mathbb{Z}$ by the tactic `linear_combination`, using the explicit coefficients above. They are then transferred to $\mathbb{N}$ by writing $z = w + f$, $y = z + e$, $x = y + d$, which avoids truncated subtraction.
- The curvature is the natural number $\mathtt{bD}\,a\,x = (x-y)v - (y-z)u$. Lean first proves $eu < dv$, so this truncated subtraction is the true value.

- The counting arguments use `Finset.card_le_mul_card_image_of_maps_to`: the number of good indices is at most the size of the parameter box times the largest fiber.
- The divisor bound $\tau(n)^k \le C_k n$ (Lemma 2.2) is the file `DivisorPowerBound.lean` from the `openai/math` repository [7] (Apache-2.0), vendored unchanged except for its import lines.
- Lemma 7.1(2) is checked by `linear_combination` with the coefficients given in its proof, which were found by polynomial division. Corollary 7.2 proves $L \ge 1$ directly from the identity, since L is an integer by definition.
- The project has about 2500 lines of Lean. `lake build` rebuilds it in under a minute once Mathlib is built.

10. Limits of the method

Proposition 7.3 removes the divisor loss from the local bound, but the exponent is still $3/10$. The local bound $T \ll a^{1/2}A^{-1/3}$ and the drop bound $T \ll A^{1/2}$ (up to the divisor factor) both allow $T \asymp a^{3/10}$ at $A \asymp a^{3/5}$. Even an ideal short-interval divisor estimate with G constant leaves this balance unchanged. So sharpening constants or improving the divisor counts cannot give a logarithmic bound. Further progress needs to restrict *which* configurations of the parameters (u, v, w, z, D, E, F) can occur together along a single orbit.

There is no obvious monotonicity to exploit. The curvatures D_i of successive blocks need not decrease. For $a = 13242$ the orbit of 255 begins

$$255,\ 237,\ 207,\ 201,\ 177,\ 144,\ 138,\ 132,\ \ldots$$

with quotients $51, 55, 63, 65, 74, 91, 95, 100, \ldots$. The curvatures of the first five blocks are $24, 12, 6, 111, 30$, all for blocks that lie within a factor of two.

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